survey of women loco pilots this year. An overwhelming majority said they had never worked in a locomotive with a toilet, some blamed the hardships of train duty for their miscarriage," says S.K. Pandhi, working president of the IRLRO, which has sent the survey results to the labour ministry.

Top officials do not deny that women face hardships, but they say the situation has improved a lot over the years. Responding to queries sent by

In a railways workforce of 1.2 mn in Mar. 2023, 97,000 were women. They numbered 2,171 out of 110,000+ loco & assistant loco pilots

INDIA TODAY, the Railways said that a number of measures are followed while deploying women on duty. "Female running staff is booked (placed on duty) in sections that have running rooms with separate restrooms and toilets for female staff. They are also booked for running duties where they can return to their headquarters (home) by evening. Pregnant/ expectant female staff is utilised in crew lobbies or places that do not have a very strenuous nature of duty," says the ministry. If such empathy is being practised, it seems to have missed most of its intended recipients.

His combative reply in Parliament notwithstanding, Vaishnaw formed a three-member committee in the Railway Board on July 27 to recommend improvements in the working conditions of loco pilots, including in their duty hours—the 2016 revisions to the railway service rules require loco pilots to be on duty at a stretch for not more than 11 hours, and the total "running duty" (in a moving train) to not stretch beyond nine hours. The committee is to submit its recommendations in 30 days. As India's loco pilots wait for the recommendations of Vaishnaw's committee, the female workforce will be hoping the suggestions will bring them reason to cheer as well. ■



WORKED UP Protesters demand permanent appointment for those who have cleared the teachers' eligibility test

GUJARAT PROTESTS

THE SLATE IS CLEAN

By Jumana Shah

Tejas Majithiya, a resident of Gujarat's Una town, is a science graduate, has a Master's degree too in science, has completed a Bachelor in Education (BEd) course and also cleared the state government's teachers' aptitude test (TAT, for recruitment as teaching staff in a government-run or aided school) in 2023. Despite these wall-to-wall qualifications, however, the 29-year-old has yet to find a job, allegedly owing to the Gujarat government's delayed recruitments for teaching jobs. And he is not the only one. There are thousands out there like him. Take 28-year-old Jaymin Patel of Sabarkantha district and 29-year-old Dilipsinh Rathod from Ahmedabad. They, too, have cleared TAT and the teachers' eligibility test (TET), and completed BEd, and BCom and MCom, respectively, but are waiting to find employment as teachers.

It's been more than a month since the Gujarat government last offered a promise on this. And the subsequent tardiness in action means the issue refuses to die down. In July, the government said there would be teacher recruitments on a vastly expanded scale. This was in response to sustained protests by those who had cleared TAT and TET in 2023 but had yet to receive appointments. Initially, in June, the Gujarat government had announced recruitment for 7,500 teachers in the coming three months, but the intensity of protests had persuaded it to scale that number up to 24,700, to be recruited by December. This includes 7,500 teachers for